

1. The Etymology and Evolution of the Name "Quthing"

The name "**Quthing**" is identified as a linguistic adaptation of an indigenous click-root, reflecting the transition from a San landscape descriptor to a Sotho-style locative.

- **Linguistic Roots:** The sources indicate that the palatal click ("**Q**") is a defining marker of San identity within the linguistic landscape. The root "**Qithi**" (or variants like **!Qiti** or **ǀQiti**) likely originated as an onomatopoeia or a description of **specific geological formations**, such as a cave or a type of stone 1, 2.
- **Adaptation into Sotho/Nguni Frameworks:** The transition from San roots to formal place-names involved grafting Bantu linguistic structures onto indigenous sounds. In **Quthing**, the Sotho locative suffix "**-ing**" was added to the click-root. This is compared to the hybrid name "**Mqithi**," which combines the Xhosa personal prefix "**M-**" with the San root "**Qithi**," serving as a "linguistic fossil" of assimilation 2, 3.
- **Drifting Meaning:** The name "Quthing" refers to the southernmost district of Lesotho, which served as a core territory for the San-Phuti alliance 4.

Source Information: *The Maluti-Cacadu Migration Pipeline: A Linguistic and Historical Reconstruction of the Qithi San Lineage*, Section 1: The Etymology of Qithi — Person, Place, or Object. **Direct Quote:** "In many Southern San dialects, phonetic variations like **!Qiti** or **ǀQiti** are used onomatopoeically or to describe specific geological formations... it is probable that 'Qithi' was originally a descriptor for a physical place—perhaps a specific cave or a type of stone—which eventually became associated with the leader of the group residing there." 2

2. The San-Phuti Matrix in Quthing District

The Quthing district was a 19th-century "cradle" for a fused **San-Phuti identity**, largely defined by the leadership of **Chief Moorosi**.

- **Cultural and Biological Bonds:** Chief Moorosi's Phuti clan was deeply integrated with the Maluti San (**AbaThwa**). Moorosi himself had San maternal ancestry and two San wives, establishing a political and biological bond between the groups 5, 6.
- **The Tracking and Fighting Core:** San fighters were central to Phuti military strength. During the 1879 war, San armed with bows and arrows fought alongside Moorosi's forces against British colonial troops 6.
- **Linguistic Identification:** The importance of the San within this matrix is highlighted by the Phuti military password used during the siege of Moorosi's Mountain—"**Moroo**"—the Xhosa word for "Bushman" 6, 7.

Source Information: *SONQUA | Earthworm Express*, Chapter 6, Page 77. **Direct Quote:** "The role of the San in supporting the Phuthi at this time, and their importance in Phuthi society in general, is probably indicated by the fact that the password for Phuthi who wanted access to the mountain during the siege... was 'Moroo', meaning 'Bushman'." 7

3. The Painting and Oral Traditions of Quthing

Archival records, specifically those of **Marion Walsham How**, preserve the testimonies of late-surviving click-speaking artists in the Quthing district.

- **The Painter Masitise:** In 1932, How was visited at the British residency in **Moyeni, Quthing**, by a Phuthi artist named **Masitise**. He demonstrated San-taught painting techniques on the residency's verandah walls 8, 9.
- **Memory of Lineages:** Masitise's paintings included a historical battle between San chiefs **Soai and Mphaki**, illustrating a direct lineage of artistic and historical memory 10, 11.
- **Testimony of Mapote:** Another Phuthi artist, **Mapote** (Moorosi's son), testified to his upbringing in San caves where he painted with his **San half-brothers**. He provided details on pigments like **qhang qhang** (red ochre) and the spiritual status of those "of the eland" 12, 13.

Source Information: SONQUA | *Earthworm Express*, Chapter 8, Page 98. **Direct Quote:** "how was living at Moyeni in the Quthing District in 1932 when she was visited by a Phuthi artist named Masitise, who offered to do some paintings for her on the sandstone wall of the verandah of the British residency building. Some of the Phuthi people were said to have been taught how to paint by the San..." 8

4. The Flight from Quthing to the Transkeian Borderlands

The fall of Moorosi's Mountain in 1879 triggered a direct southern evacuation from the Quthing valleys into the river basins of the Eastern Cape.

- **Refugee Corridors:** Families evacuated the Quthing/Mohale's Hoek district, moving through the **Zastron/Matlakeng** frontier toward **East Griqualand** and the **Cacadu (White Kei)** basin 6, 14.
- **Geographic Names in Exile:** Groups fleeing Moorosi's defeat carried commemorative names. A prominent example is **Molosi Qwabi**, a San man of the AmaQithi clan whose name was a linguistic evolution of "Moorosi," intended to preserve the memory of their Phuthi ally and their highland homeland 4, 15.
- **Institutionalization:** This migration ended in the establishment of **Qithi Village** in the Lady Frere district, where San leadership settled adjacent to the Thembu Great Place 16.

Source Information: *The Maluti-Cacadu Migration Pipeline: A Linguistic and Historical Reconstruction of the Qithi San Lineage*, Section 4: Chief Moorosi's War (1879) and the Southern Sotho-San Networks. **Direct Quote:** "The fall of Moorosi in 1879 represented a catastrophic loss for the San, triggering a further drift toward the Eastern Cape river basins." 6

5. Phonetic Variants and Orthographic Shifts

Analysis of proper names along the Lesotho-Eastern Cape border reveals a consistent pattern of **orthographic shift** as names moved between Sotho, San, and Nguni contexts.

- **Shift from Sotho to Xhosa/San:** The name "**Moorosi**" (or Morosi) shifted to "**Molosi**" in family lineages as Xhosa speakers found the original Sotho pronunciation difficult 4.
- **Onomastic Drifting:** The sources describe "**name drifting**" as a hallmark of this frontier, where descriptive identifiers (like those for lifestyle or landscape features) evolved into hereditary clan names like the **AmaQithi** 2, 17.

- **Linguistic Fossils:** Researchers document how names like "**Mqithi**" synthesized Xhosa prefixes with San click-roots, marking the physical and social movement of these people from the **Maloti** to the **Cacadu** 2, 3.

Source Information: *The Maluti-Cacadu Migration Pipeline: A Linguistic and Historical Reconstruction of the Qithi San Lineage*, Section 3: The Lifaqane/Difaqane Melting Pot and Trans-Generational Name Drifting. **Direct Quote:** "The transition of the AmaQithi from a collection of San families into a formal clan is a classic example of 'name drifting.' As these groups moved south out of the Lesotho borderlands, their identifiers evolved from descriptive terms for their lifestyle into hereditary clan names." 17